Mutual funds (MF) have emerged as a favourite investment tool. Nilesh Shah, MD, Kotak Mahindra Asset Management Company, said while all the macro indicators so far have been positive for the markets, a deficient monsoon could play spoiler. Moreover, market volatility is something investors will have to live with. This was followed by a high-powered panel comprising leaders from the MF industry—Nimesh Shah, CEO, ICICI Prudential MF; Vetri Subramaniam, MD & CEO, UTI Asset Management; Rishi Kohli, chief investment officer, Jio BlackRock Mutual Fund; and Kailash Kulkarni, CEO, HSBC Mutual Fund—on the prospects of the sector. They seemed to agree that the economic fundamentals could not have been better for India. However, the war and tepid corporate earnings were a concern. Radhika Gupta, MD & CEO, Edelweiss Mutual Fund, said she was a big believer in investing in India, and preferred a multi-cap portfolio with meaningful exposure to both large and mid-cap companies.

Economists D.K. Joshi of Crisil, Ila Patnaik of the Aditya Birla Group and Madan Sabnavis of the Bank of Baroda debated the Reserve Bank of India's recent measures to boost capital inflows. Sabnavis had a word of caution: The markets were overvalued, and there is a big reduction in the overall quantity of investable resources. So, markets could remain under pressure. Patnaik wanted more discussions around the RBI move, because it marked a shift in policy that always preferred equity to debt. Joshi was optimistic that the war had ended and that inflation was still under control.

No discussion today would be complete without analysing the impact of artificial intelligence, and Srikanth Velamakanni, group chief executive, Fractal, and chairperson, Nasscom, stressed the need to have our most critical infrastructure continuously tested using the latest AI models to identify vulnerabilities. "Security has to be built into systems by design, not added later," he said.

These were only some of the many conversations that converged on a common message: navigating a more challenging financial environment will require innovative ways to attract investors and sustain India's long-term growth story. The pages that follow delve into the ideas and insights shared by the speakers. ■ ***—by M.G. Arun***

INVESTING WISELY IN VOLATILE TIMES



"There was probably under-investment and shorting in the markets that resulted in a pull-back during the war. There will be worries ahead in terms of monsoon and deep technology. The returns will be moderate, volatility will be high, one will have to manage it"

NILESH SHAH, *MD, Kotak Mahindra Asset Management Co.*

INDIA'S MOMENT: REAL ESTATE'S EMERGENCE AS A POWERFUL ASSET CLASS



"Growth of real estate will happen at a faster pace compared to the GDP growth... However, the 20% decline in affordable housing sales is concerning"

"Earlier, you had to buy a house to invest in real estate. Now, you can have an IPO*, REITs**, and fractionalisation# is not far away"

NIRANJAN HIRANANDANI
Founder & Chairman, Hiranandani Group

INVESTING THROUGH UNCERTAINTY: WINNING IN A VOLATILE MARKET



"The premise of having 10-15% of your portfolio abroad is a strong one as different markets outperform at different stages of the economic cycle"

"If I were to build a portfolio for the next ten years, I would build a multi-cap portfolio with meaningful exposure to both large and mid-cap companies"

RADHIKA GUPTA
MD & CEO, Edelweiss Mutual Fund

**Initial Public Offering **Real Estate Investment Trusts #Breaking down the ownership of a real-estate asset into smaller, tradeable shares*